It is not an exaggeration to say that the art of making a sitar parallels the making of a fine sitar player. Seeking and identifying raw potential, drawing out its rich promise, shaping it with patience and artistry, toiling over exacting details, ultimately to deliver the sublime music it was destined for, is common to both journeys.





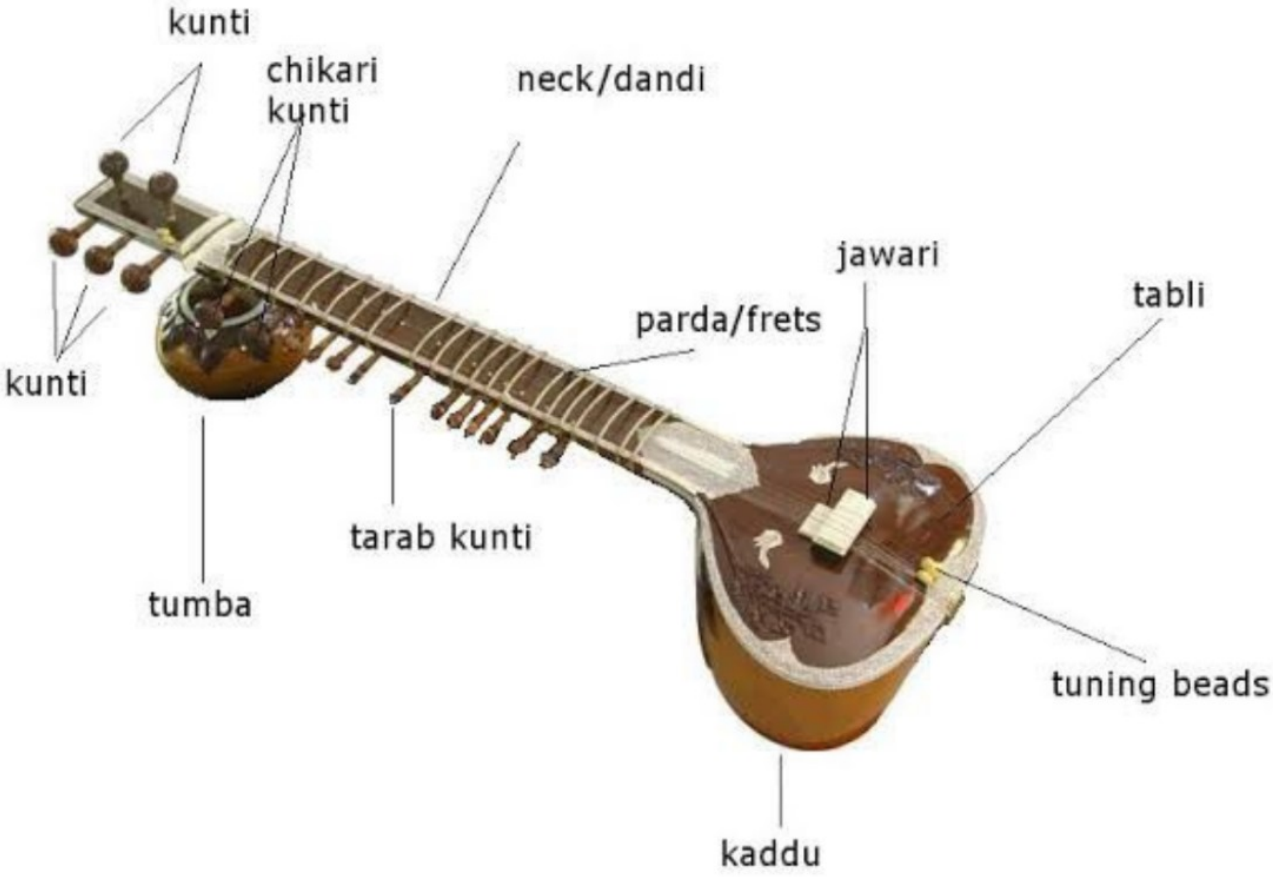
Who invented the sitar? It is commonly attributed to the 13thC Indo-Persian mystic poet-singer, Amir Khusrau, known best for the early development of North Indian classical music. However, there is no evidence of the existence of the sitar until the last days of the Mughal Empire, so its origin remains a mystery.

The best sitars are said to be made from Burma teak that has been seasoned for generations. For sitars that are specially commissioned, instrument builders look for old Burma teak columns used in old colonial-style villas. Understandably, the sources of very old seasoned wood is a highly guarded trade secret.



From raw pumpkin gourd to exquisite finished form

How is this music made? When a string is plucked, the vibration travels through the bridge to the round resonating chamber and from there to the ‘sympathetic’ lower strings, creating the sitar's distinctive sound. The sitar's size, construction and design, and the movable frets, also contribute to its rich tonal qualities.


kunti
chikari
kunti
neck/dandi
jawari
tabli
parda/frets
kunti
tarab kunti
tumba
tuning beads
kaddu



Oil on canvas, reminiscent of the 19thC
Raja Ravi Varma style

Happenings in Handmade

A CCI initiative

February 2024

Handmade harmony

The meticulous craft of making a sitar

